3 The Revolt of 1857

There had always been opposition to the East India Company, across regions from various groups. The resistance put forth by the tribals, peasants, and religious groups had remained localized and haphazardly organized. The Revolt of 1857 was a significant uprising against British rule in which disgruntled princes, disengaged soldiers, and disillusioned individuals took part.

Difference between the British Colonists in India and Earlier Invaders

- The **establishment of the British Empire in India altered the country's economic, social, and political landscape**. Around 1608, British settlers arrived in India. The arrival of Europeans brought about several changes in Indian society's socio-economic and political spheres.
- The major difference between the early Invaders and the British Empire was that none of the previous Invaders **brought structural changes in the Indian society, administration and economy.**

Causes behind 1857 Revolt

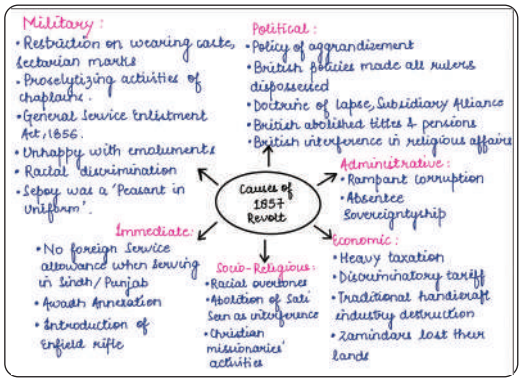


Fig. 3.1: 1857 Revolt Causes
Diagram Type: *Hub & Spoke*

- **Political Causes:**
  - **War and Conquests:** The East India Company seeded dissatisfaction and disaffection among the dispossessed ruling dynasties.
    - **For example, Lord Dalhousie humiliated the royal dynasty by annexing Punjab**. Dalip Singh was deposed and deported to England and assets of Lahore Darbar were put up for sale.
  - **Subsidiary alliance:**
    - This alliance prohibited the rulers of India from having separate armed forces.
    - They had to pay for the "**Subsidiary forces**" that the company would use to defend them.
    - **Hyderabad (1798), Mysore (1799), Tanjore (1799), Awadh (1801), Peshwa (Marathas) (1802), and Scindia (1803),** entered into Subsidiary alliances.
    - As a result, these Indian kings surrendered their foreign policy to the British, many soldiers lost their jobs.
    - Thus, the East India Company's goal of "**Effective control**" and the gradual extinction of the Indian native kingdoms took a definite shape.
  - **Doctrine of Lapse:** The principalities of **Satara, Jaipur, Sambalpur, Bhagat, Udaipur, Jhansi, and Nagpur** were annexed by Dalhousie. The overthrow of **Wajid Ali Shah** (Oudh, 1856) caused rage and hatred to spread across the nation.
  - **Disrespect for regional rulers:** The Muslims and the Hindus both felt resentful at the humiliation of the nominal Mughal emperors with the attitude of Dalhousie, Canning, and East India Company. As a result, they decided to enter into an alliance with the rebels.
  - **Feeling of superiority**: The British sought to perpetuate racial myths of white superiority through a deliberate policy of discrimination and segregation. This caused great distress among Indians.
  - **Suspension of Pension:** The annual stipend of **Rani Jindan** had been cut from **15,000 pounds to 1,200 pounds, and Pensions of** Lakshmi Bai, Nana Sahib, Nawab of Tanjore and Carnatic were abolished. This prompted them to rebel against the British.
- **Administrative Causes:**
  - **New Administrative System**: The British government officials were unapproachable as well as arrogant and scornful towards the Indians. As a result, the Indians found it difficult to adapt to the new administrative structure.
  - **Deprived of benefits and Privileges:** The Indian aristocracy lost social and economic privileges, due to the annexation program of East India.
    - **For instance**, Indian kings donated rent-free estates to several religious and educational organizations. The Company confiscated rent-free property by appointing the **Inam Commission**.
    - **For example,** the **Commission in Bombay** alone seized over 20,000 properties.
  - **Exclusion of Indians from lucrative posts:** Indians were not allowed to work at higher positions including those in the military and civil sectors. Contempt for Indians and racial discrimination brought discontent and a sense of humiliation.

- **Prejudiced Rule of Law**: The British legal system was **complex**, and delivering justice was **costly** and **time-consuming.** The complicated administrative system further increased resentment toward the British and served as another reason for the great Mutiny.

- **Economic Causes**:
  - **Ruin of the Mercantile Class:**
    - British imposed high tariffs on Indian goods, crippling Indian trade.
    - By the mid-19th century, Indian exports of cotton and silk products nearly ceased.
  - **Land Revenue System:**
    - Indians had to provide letters of grant to prove property rights legitimacy.
    - Inam Commission, established by Lord Dalhousie, investigated landlords' title documents.
  - **Destroyed indigenous industries:**
    - Handmade products couldn't compete with English goods.
    - Indian manufacturing suffered from free trade and lack of protective duties on English machine-made goods.
  - **Exploitation through Plantation:**
    - Plantation industries like indigo, jute, tea, and coffee made life difficult for planters.
    - Inhumane treatment and persecution of planters fueled resentment and contributed to the mutiny.
  - **Economic Drain:**
    - Criticism of economic exploitation fueled anti-British sentiment.
    - Economic nationalism fostered skepticism of British intentions, paving the way for national movements.
- **Socio-Religious Causes:**
  - **Attitude of Social Exclusiveness:** Indians were displeased with British social exclusivity policies and their arrogant treatment. They could be insulted, attacked, and even killed by the British. **For instance** - Every native was forced to salute all Englishmen in the streets.
  - **Missionary Activities:** According to the **charter act of 1813**, missionaries were allowed to disseminate their faith and Western education. Indians were suspicious of intervention in societal conventions and behaviours through Christian missionaries.
  - **Social Legislations:** The British made an effort to abolish social evils such as **child marriage, infanticide, and Sati etc.** The orthodox were opposed to the legislation.
  - **Empowering Rights:** Laws related to the Right of inheritance, Widow remarriage, and schools, and colleges for Western education for women were not well received by Hindus.
- **Military Causes:**
  - **Afghan War Debacle:**
    - British military discipline plummeted after the defeat in the first Afghan war (1838–42).
    - Historians note that the British were forced to withdraw from Afghanistan, with only one soldier surviving.
  - **Erosion of Loyalty to the Army:**
    - Indian troops began recognizing their role in aiding English expansion and exploiting their own people.
    - Fear for their future grew due to recruitment of Gurkhas, Sikhs, and irregular forces in Punjab and other frontier areas.
  - **Legislation to Go Abroad:** The General Service Enlistment Act (1856) mandated sepoys to accept duty to fight overseas, leading to resentment toward the British.
  - **Disparity among Indian and British Soldiers:**
    - A significant gap existed between the British and Indian armies.
    - Indian troops realized attacking British power in India could overwhelm it.
  - **Influence of outside events**
    - Such as first Afghan war(1838-42), Punjab war(1845-49), crimean wars(1854-56)
    - Many Indian soldiers fought in the Crimean War, where British failures undermined morale in India.
  - **Lubricated Cartridges:**
    - Sepoys had to bite cartridges' tips, and rumors spread that they were lubricated with cow and pig fat.
    - Sepoys were incensed by the perceived insult to their religious beliefs.

Beginning and Spread of the Revolt

- The 1857 uprising took place in Meerut, where **85 cavalry regiment sepoys** were sentenced to 2-10 years in prison for refusing to use greased cartridges. The following day, on **May 10, 1857**, three regiments went on the offensive. They assassinated British officers and broke open the prison doors to free their comrades.
- **Mangal Pandey, 34th Native Infantry sepoy** was the first soldier to openly defy command. On March 29, 1857, he assassinated two **English officers in Barrackpore, near Calcutta.** He was apprehended, tried, and killed. Barrackpore regiments were disbanded.

Choice of Bahadur Shah as Symbolic Head

- The Long reign of the Mughal dynasty had become a traditional symbol of India's political unity. As a result, Delhi was soon to become a hotbed of rebellion, with Bahadur Shah as its symbol.
- Bahadur Shah Zafar, who was elderly and powerless, was crowned Emperor of India.

Regional Variations in the Revolt

- Even though the uprising was large and widespread, it was still mostly fragmented, unorganized, and localized.
- **Punjab, the United Provinces, Rohilkhand, Oudh,** the territory between the Narmada and the Chambal, as well as the **western portions of Bengal and Bihar** on the North-Eastern border, were the areas impacted.
- **Afghanistan** was cordial during Dost Mohammad's rule. **Rajputana** was dependable, while **Sindh** was quiet.

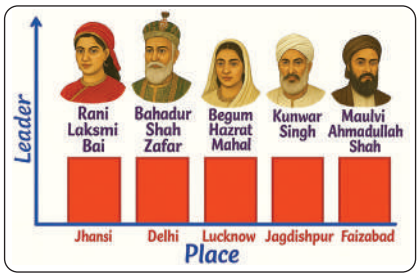


Fig. 3.2: Major Leaders and Places of revolt

Delhi

- Delhi was captured by the sepoys on **May 12, 1857**. The political agent from England, **Simon Fraser**. Lt. Willoughby attempted to fight back but was ultimately defeated; as a result, he set the Delhi ammunition dump on fire.
- Bahadur Shah II was declared the Emperor of Delhi. He was merely acting as the leader; Bakht Khan held the reins of power. On **September 20, 1857**, the English took back control of Delhi.
- Delhi was liberated by **Henry Bernard and BG Wilson**.
- Bahadur Shah II, who sought refuge in the Humayun Tomb, was **detained by Lt. Hudson and. He was deported to Rangoon.**
- **John Nicholson** scaled the Kashmir gate and took control of the city entrance, suffering serious injuries.

Bihar

- **Kunwar Singh** was a leader during the Indian Rebellion of 1857. He belonged to **Jagdispur,** Bhojpur district, Bihar.
- At the age of **80**, he led a selected band of armed soldiers against the troops under the command of the British East India Company. He was an expert in the art of guerilla warfare.
- He was assisted by **Babu Amar Singh, and his commander-in-chief, Hare Krishna Singh**.

Other States

Places	Leaders of Revolts
Assam	Diwan Manram Dutta fought against the British
Maharashtra	Satara – Rangu Bapuji Gupte
Himachal Pradesh	Kullu– Rana Pratap Singh & Veer Singh

Weakness of the 1857 Revolt

- **Localized Nature:**
  - Despite its intensity, the 1857 uprising was limited in scope and organization.
  - **Dr. R.C. Mazumdar** described it as localized, constrained, and poorly organized rather than a nationwide movement.
- **Unequal Spreads:**
  - The uprising was predominantly concentrated in Northern and Central India, with Eastern, Southern, and Western regions less affected.
  - The armies in Madras and Bombay remained loyal to the British East India Company.
- **Lack of Organizational Cohesion and Unity:**
  - Indian rebels lacked proper organization and faced weak central leadership.
  - Despite individual bravery, they lacked experience in coordination and concerted action.
- **Lack of Leadership:**
  - The last Mughal emperor lacked strength and leadership compared to the British. His inability to effectively lead and safeguard regions contributed to the failure of the revolt.
  - Few capable leaders like Babu Kunwar Singh, the Rani of Jhansi, Tatya Tope, and Nana Sahib emerged.
    - However, overall leadership was fragmented.
- **Individual Rivalries among the Mutineers:**
  - Leaders of the revolt were plagued by personal rivalries and jealousy, hindering unity.
  - Continuous intrigue against one another weakened the movement.
- **No Unified Ideology:**
  - Lack of prominent leaders hindered the formation of a unified ideology.
  - The revolt lacked a cohesive vision or direction.
- **Poor Arms and Ammunition:**
  - Rebels had inferior weaponry compared to the British, who possessed modern rifles and arms.
  - Indian rebels had outdated and limited cannons, swords, and firearms.
- **Superiority of the British in War Technology:**
  - British naval power was unmatched during the period, giving them a significant advantage.
  - The British army, with its superior technology and resources, overwhelmed the Indian rebels.

Aftermaths of the Rebellion

Positive Impacts

- **Transfer of Power:**
  - The transfer of political and administrative power from the East India Company to the British crown was achieved through the **GoI Act 1858.**
  - Under this Act, governance was under the crown through a **Secretary of State** who was made directly responsible to the British Parliament.
- **Queen Proclamation 1858 and onwards roadmap:** She announced the acquisition of the Indian administration and assured the people that they would be treated at par with the subjects of the British Crown.
- **Abolished Annexation policy:** British government gave up annexation policies like the doctrine of lapse and guaranteed the integrity of the Indian states.
- **Right of adoption:** The British authorities realized the importance of the Princely States and hence the right of adoption by the native princes was duly acknowledged.
- **Freedom of religion and equal treatment:** As per the proclamation of the Queen, freedom of religion was granted to all the people in India and the administration vowed never to hurt anyone's religious sentiments in any way.
- **Occupancy rights**: Following the Bengal Rent Act of 1859, farmers who had owned particular fields for more than 12 years were entitled to occupancy rights.
- **Other reforms:**
  - Universities were established at Kolkata and Madras
  - Introduction of Code of Criminal Procedure
  - Enactment of Indian High Courts Act in 1861
  - Indian Penal Code (1858)
  - Passing of Indian Councils Act, 1861 introduced a portfolio system in India

Negative Impacts

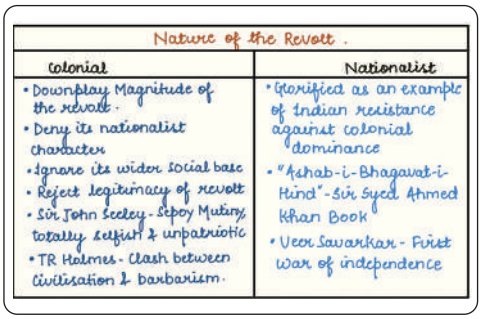
- **Increase in Racial Animosity:** Indians were embarrassed and insulted because the British painted them as being unreliable. Racial hostility grew between the English and the Indians as a result of this.
- **Reversal of Social Reforms**: The Revolt persuaded the British that interfering with India's established socio-religious practices was counterproductive. The British were forced to take a backseat as a result of the vehement resistance to the social regulations.
- **Increased focus on administrative changes**: After the Revolt of 1857, the British decided to focus on establishing a stable and effective administration rather than bringing Western concepts and reforming an established Asian society.
- **Policy of Divide and Rule:** Post-revolt, the British had applied the most unscrupulous policy to divide the Indians into castes and classes. One community was used against another. Hindus were enraged among castes, and Muslims were forced to fight with Hindus.
- **Replacement of Territorial conquest with economic exploitation:** With the failure of the Great Rebellion, the era of British territorial conquest came to an end and the territorial conquests gave place to economic exploitation of the Indians by the Britishers.
- **Slowdown in Muslim Renaissance:** Muslim Renaissance which had been growing in Delhi before the Mutiny got an irreparable setback. According to **C.F. Andrews,** it's not difficult to trace the fatal havoc to the budding spiritual life that mutiny wrought.
- **Structural change in Army**: It led to drastic reduction of Indians soldiers from **2.4 lakhs in 1857 to 1.4 lakh by 1863,** on the other hand, European soldiers increased from 45,000 to 65,000.

Views and Perspectives of Prominent Personalities

Said by	Statements/ Views
S. N. Sen	The causes of the Revolt were inherent in the Constitution of British rule. It was a war started for the protection of religion but goes into a war of independence
Maulana Abul Kalam Azad	Indian National character had sunk very low; Held British responsible for the revolt and accepted general discontent among people
Pt. Jawahar Lal Nehru	Not only sepoy mutiny, formed the shape of civil rebellion. The real form was feudalism though some nationalist elements were also present.
Stanley Wolpert	It was far more than a mutiny, ...yet much less than a first war of Independence
V.D.Savarkar	First war of Indian war of Independence
Dr. Tarachand	The Revolt was specifically middle in character & represents the powerless class to get back their lost power

Nature of the Revolt

- **Historians' perspectives on the Nature of the Uprising:**
  - The British labeled it as a "Military Revolt," lacking popular support or prominent leadership.
  - Indian patriots, however, hailed it as the "National War of Independence."
- **The Nature and Character of the Revolt of 1857 A.D. included:**
  - **Military Revolt**
  - Attempt to restore Mughal Power
  - Aristocrat Reaction
  - Peasant Reaction
  - National Revolution
  - Racial struggle for supremacy between Black and White
  - Struggle between Oriental and Occidental Civilization and Culture
  - National War of Independence
- Among these, Military Revolt and the National War of Independence were the most significant interpretations endorsed by the historians.



Nature of the Revolt.

Colonial	Nationalist
• Downplay Magnitude of the revolt. • Deny its nationalist character • Ignore its wider social base • Reject legitimacy of revolt • Sir John Seeley - Sepoy Mutiny totally selfish & unpatriotic • TR Holmes - Clash between civilisation & barbarism.	• Glorified as an example of Indian resistance against colonial dominance • "Asbab-i-Bhagavat-i-Hind" - Sir Syed Ahmed Khan Book • Veer Savarkar - First War of independence

Fig. 3.3: Nature of the Revolt

Perspective: A Military Revolt

- **Historian Views:**
  - According to historians like **Sir John Lawrence and Seelay,** the Revolt of 1857 AD was a military uprising.
  - In the book "**The Sepoy Mutiny and The Revolt of 1857**," **R.C. Mujumdar** makes the case that the uprising was not an Independence War.
- **Reasons for this argument:**
  - **Localised Spread near Military Centers**: The revolt had **only spread to a small portion of Northern India**; it had not spread to many other areas of North India or Southern India.
  - **Erupted in Military Areas**: The uprising began in the military cantonment area and developed and gained influence at the military centres.
  - **Active Participation of Soldiers:** When soldiers started taking up arms against the British, then tyrants like Nana Sahib, Bahadur Shah, and the Rani of Jhansi came forward.
  - **Suppressed by British soldiers**: If it was the National War of Independence, then a small portion of British troops could not have suppressed the revolt.
  - **Mainly untouched from Villages**: The 1857 uprising saw very little participation and was contained to the cities and towns, and did not spread to the surrounding villages.

Perspective: First War of Independence

- **Dr. K.M. Panikar** has called that revolt a National Revolution. **V.D. Savarkar and Ashok Mehta** have called it the War of Independence.
- In the Words of **Pt. Nehru:** The revolt was much more than a military mutiny and it spread rapidly and achieved the character of a popular rebellion and a war of Indian Independence
- **Reasons for this argument:**
  - Its spread was wide and people from all sections of society participated.
  - The native soldiers, zamindars and native rulers also showed their active participation.
  - The revolt remained in force for many months which could not have been possible without the support of common people.
  - Both Hindus and Muslims took part in the revolt jointly against the British.
  - Mostly, Common people and citizens were punished by the British.
  - Along with men, women also took an active part in that revolt.

Religious Unity in Regional Battles of 1857

- **Ayodhya (Baba Ramcharan Das & Maulana Ameer Ali):**
  - Maulana Ameer Ali, known as the Maulvi of Ayodhya, and Baba Ramcharan Das from Hanuman Garhi led the armed resistance efforts.
  - They were captured and executed together, hanged on a tamarind tree at Kuber Teela in Ayodhya.
- **Rohilkhand (Khan Bahadur Khan & Khushi Ram):**
  - After the proclamation of an independent Indian government in Delhi on May 11, 1857, Khan Bahadur Khan became the viceroy of the Mughal emperor.
  - He formed a committee with eight members, comprising Hindus and Muslims, to govern the state, with Khushi Ram as his deputy.
  - This government respected Hindu sentiments by prohibiting cow slaughter.
  - Khan and Khushi Ram led troops in several battles against the British but were ultimately defeated in a significant battle at Bareilly. They were executed along with many followers outside the old Kotwali on March 20, 1860.

- **Central India:**
  - Jhansi: Rani Laxmibai, along with Muslim commanders Ghulam Ghouse Khan and Khuda Bakhsh, fiercely resisted British forces.
  - Muslim lady Munzar, Rani Laxmibai's personal bodyguard, sacrificed her life alongside the Rani in the battle at Kotah-ki-Sarai in Gwalior on June 18, 1858.
  - Malwa region: Tatia Tope, Rao Saheb, Laxmi Bai, Ferozshah, and Moulvi Fazal Haq formed a joint command, mobilizing a large rebel army of 70-80 thousand fighters. This army won numerous battles against the British.
- **Delhi:**
  - Both Hindu and Muslim communities collaborated to undermine British rule, declaring the Delhi Sultan Bahadurshah Zafar as their leader.
  - They pledged that if successful, Bahadurshah Zafar would be reinstated as the Sultan of Delhi, showcasing unity and solidarity.

Uprising of 1857: An Important Watershed in the Evolution of British Policies Towards Colonial India (UPSC 2016)

- The 1857 uprising significantly influenced British policies toward Colonial India for the next 90 years. Instead of expanding their empire, British authorities began concentrating more on its consolidation.
- It is seen as a watershed that marks the transition between an era of swift reform and a period of rigid conservatism. The British brought changes in following sectors:
  - **Infrastructural Development**: In the years following the uprising, the Suez Canal was opened in 1869 which eased travel between England and India.
  - **Governance: Lord Mayo** began the decentralization trend for revenue in 1870. Later, Lord Ripon prolonged the procedure much more.
  - British colonial rulers split India into the **Bengal, Bombay, and Madras Presidencies**. The Governor's Executive Council was tasked with overseeing the government.
  - **Service Matters:**
    - **Civil Services:** The legal minimum age to apply for civil service in 1853 was 23. In 1860, it was decreased to 22, in 1866 to 21, and in 1876 to 19.
    - **Military management:** The British attempted to separate the military forces into various groups.
    - **Education:** In contrast to prior ideologies, Higher education and intellectuals were despised since they were considered tools of contemporary nationalism.
    - **Press & Communication:** To prohibit publishing in Indian languages, the Vernacular Press Act of 1878 was passed.

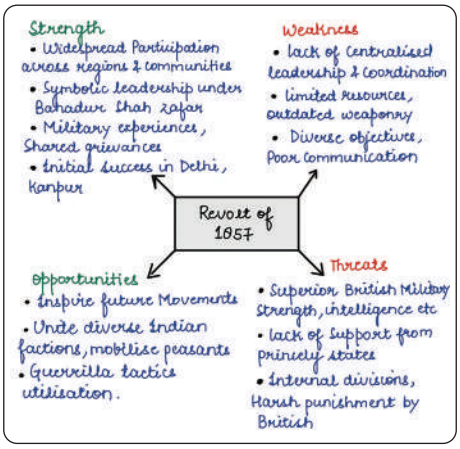


Fig. 3.4: Revolt of 1857
Diagram Type: *SWOT*

Despite the rebels' failure, the impetus was put on the British government to alter its approach to India. The East India Company lost control of India to the British crown in August 1858, and Queen Victoria was named Empress of India. The East India Company's rule came to an end as a result.

Conclusion

The revolt of 1857 **may not be classified as black or white**. However, it had seeds against imperialism and united people for nationalism. In spite of its limitations and weaknesses, the effort of the sepoys to liberate the country from foreign rule was a patriotic act. It established local traditions of resistance to British rule, which paved the way for a modern national movement.

Key Words

Revolt of 1857, British colonialism, Doctrine of Lapse, Subsidiary Alliance, Economic exploitation, Racial discrimination, Military grievances, Hindu-Muslim unity, Bahadur Shah Zafar, Regional variations, British policies post-1857, Queen's Proclamation 1858, Governance changes, Economic Drain, Social Legislation, Lubricated Cartridges, National War of Independence.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	Why did the armies of the British East India Company– mostly comprising of Indian soldiers – win consistently against the more numerous and better-equipped armies of the Indian rulers? Give reasons.	2022
2.	Explain how the Uprising of 1857 constitutes an important watershed in the evolution of British policies towards colonial India.	2016